is often portrayed. It was primarily because of little capability to understand the situation in depth on the ground. Haidar reiterates this point:

> There are two elements. One, lack of capacity, and two, more important, lack of desire ... India has always been the last of the people around to accept that there can be different types of Taliban.[185]

X, a former Indian intelligence official active in/on Afghanistan during the 1990s and 2000s, says: 'we had no contacts with the Taliban in the 1990s ... we knew that the Pakistanis were supporting the Taliban, and in turn, we were looking for any and all anti-Pakistan outfits in Afghanistan to support.'[186] Having provided financial support to the UF, X had built very strong covert links with various anti-Taliban outfits. Viewing the Taliban as a 'monolith' that could not be engaged with, X played a pivotal role, with support from Vivek Katju and K. Raghunath in the MEA, to keep the political leadership in New Delhi away from opening channels with the Taliban. Even though X nurtured the view among the Indian leadership that more than Islam, it was the tribal loyalties that formed the glue for the Taliban, he saw the movement as a monolith under Pakistan's firm grip. Therefore, it was not just the Pakistan factor or the insurgency in Kashmir that helped the partisans' rise in 1996. A serious gap in knowledge and capacity compounded by India's economic and political resource crunch during the 1990s added weight to their force. The arrival of the BJP government in 1998 and its increasingly aggressive stance on Kashmir further strengthened the partisans. Critically, though for different reasons, Moscow, Tehran and the CAR's staunch anti-Taliban stance, coupled with the UN's condemnation of the Taliban strengthened the partisans tremendously and sealed the conciliators' defeat. Constituting a negative social construct of the Taliban (and in some cases even the Pashtuns), and a sense of realpolitik to engage with anti-Pakistan elements on the Afghan landscape, the partisans were able to influence policy in their favour.

Conclusion

Theoretical constructs such as the ACF can help conceptualise policy advocacies and unpack under-appreciated policy currents of India effectively. India's Afghanistan policy in the 1990s was more than just a negative-correlate of Pakistani actions. This was despite Pakistan's use of asymmetric warfare in